The Zimmermann Telegram

Arthur Zimmermann, conveyed by Ambassador Walter Page · February 24, 1917

Source: Zimmermann Telegram (Jan. 1917), decoded English text via the U.S. National Archives, Milestone Documents. Public domain. Non-contiguous passages are separated by [. . .]; shorter cuts inside a passage are marked with an ellipsis (. . .).

> Germany's secret proposal that Mexico join it in war against the United States — in return for Texas, New Mexico, and Arizona — was intercepted by Britain and helped push the U.S. into World War I.

The decoded telegram

"We intend to begin on the first of February unrestricted submarine warfare. We shall endeavor in spite of this to keep the United States of America neutral. In the event of this not succeeding, we make Mexico a proposal of alliance on the following basis: make war together, make peace together, generous financial support and an understanding on our part that Mexico is to reconquer the lost territory in Texas, New Mexico, and Arizona. The settlement in detail is left to you. You will inform the President of the above most secretly as soon as the outbreak of war with the United States of America is certain and add the suggestion that he should, on his own initiative, invite Japan to immediate adherence and at the same time mediate between Japan and ourselves. Please call the President's attention to the fact that the ruthless employment of our submarines now offers the prospect of compelling England in a few months to make peace." Signed, ZIMMERMANN.

Words to know

unrestricted submarine warfare — sinking any ship, including neutral and civilian vessels, without warning

neutral — not taking sides in the war

reconquer — take back by force

adherence — joining the alliance

mediate — act as a go-between to arrange peace